

Grave Robbing

I met up with Kurze, Achillea and Roboros and headed straight towards the Soul Marches. Last time I was there we had an unfortunate encounter with the New Wings, but we also found a big mausoleum, amongst other more minor things. The point of this expedition was to investigate this mausoleum and figure out what it contained. When we arrived we noticed some soultorn striders standing guard and the floor had a strange texture to it. Walking on the grass it felt unsteady, like we were walking on top of water. We saw ripples and movement underneath the grass as if something was moving there. We tested it out by throwing a rock near it, but alas it didn't react. To lead the soultorn striders away we tried to make a distraction, but when we were sneaking closer we were spotted. They attacked and the creature, what we now know to be a boneswarm, joined the fight. It made its own creatures rise above the ground before eventually joining combat itself. The fight was challenging, especially since the creature could fly. Kurze unfortunately died, but I got there in time to revive him.

We decided to explore the little church first before going to the mausoleum. I found a book underneath the wooden floor, it warned us not to enter the mausoleum and that they finally locked "him" in. In one of the crypts we see broken open manacles and marks on the walls nail marks like someone clawed at the walls. Next to it there were turf marks...counting to 80. From here on out we went to the mausoleum. It was decorated in lilies and skulls, which I vaguely remember to be connected to the god Gescath, god of life; death and decay. At the entrance there were 3 magical statues with hollow eyes. We eventually figured out we had to put something through the eyes and so we tested it with sticks. Luckily we tested it because the holes narrowed and clamped on to them. Achillea had a smart idea to test it with a bone but this turned out worse for us, as it triggered an acid rain trap. That is when Roboros had leaned on one of the statues and a sort of rod fell out of it. Checking the rest of the statues we found the remaining rods and went inside.

We entered a hallway where a tiny skeletal mouse with some sort of paper into it approached us. Roboros managed to grab it and gave me the paper, it warned us once more that the seal of the family crypt had now been broken. We enter one of two rooms where we see a big mural. It is broken in several places, but it depicts a seemingly dead humanoid on the ground, and people looking at something. We couldn't figure out what they were looking at because the mural was also broken there. There was also a harp depicted. I can recognise that it has something to do with the curse, but I can't make much else of it. I found another rod here that helped us later on to get into one of the other rooms. We should come back here to investigate it at a later date. We went to the other, smaller, room. There was a big hole through the floor and upon Roboros's firebolt we saw the big room illuminate. It was partially flooded with green water and we couldn't see much else. We decided to lower myself down to see if this was an easier way to get where we needed to be. As it turned out it was, I could spot a staircase above the water level that seemed to lead to a crypt. I remembered something about my first ever mission with the guild where we went to the old tower of Gaen. The word "family" was engraved above the doorway in Ithyrian. The structure seemed to be old, dating back to the Ithyrian empire. Apart from the staircase I saw a maze like part of catacombs and a bridge that goes further than what I could see.

I parted the waters and the others lowered themselves down. We headed straight to the family crypt. When we went inside we heard an old hoarse voice speak; "Come quickly and close the door!". I was reluctant, it was entirely possible for this to be a trap leaving us with no way out. But I decided to put my trust in my fellow striders and agreed to close the door. We spoke to some soultorn and they told us that there was a crown piece that was stolen by a skeleton roaming in the mausoleum. When we entered this place it was us that broke the seal and now things would come for us too. He pointed us in a vague direction but there was not much else we could get out of them as they started to beg to die. We saw a sort of poem carved into the wall.

"In days of yore when the crown was one,
the land was tame, its gods his march would shun
enthralled was the king to the touch of nature's beauty
felled by the whispers of fairies, the sisters
his wrath was fire, holds many he acquired
the vassals of the king had divided
an Ithyrian treasury, scattered by treachery

a chase ensued for ancient sorcery, as old as the gods beyond
by calling on its powers, they themselves indicted
the dormant land awakened and threats forgotten rose to respond

their end was bound and their domains crumbled
in the eleventh hour an accord with fey was fumbled
hunched Ithyr men bore fangs and fur
their kin they maimed and the king fled, the bedeviled cur

the curse will remain as long as the monarch lives

he took his riches and fled to this castle, forsaking his land
by decree of the spirits and fey to the earth he was damned
they quartered his crown and made it the key
his knights remain still, until he is free
follow their gaze, marked by the arcane
reforge his crown, and unseal his domain
so speaketh Drustan The Jubilant, arcanist of old"

As we were reading the poem things started to bang on the door. Luckily Achillea had barred the door with her rod of holding, which kept us safe long enough to prepare for an attack. We fought burning skulls, will-o-wisps, zombie like creatures amongst others. We managed to pull through and head towards the bridge. At the end of it we were met by a grand door that opened up to a large room with at the back a heightened platform. The skeleton stood there, decorated in plate armor and a greatsword with two purple spheres of energy and another two skeletal snakes. We fought our way through to get to the crown piece and left before more dangers showed up.